

the opportunity to download the product from us solely on the basis of its proposed features before building anything? Remember, almost no customers were willing to use our original product, so we wouldn't have had to do much apologizing when we failed to deliver. (Note that this is different from asking customers what they want. Most of the time customers don't know what they want in advance.) We could have conducted an experiment, offering customers the chance to try something and then measuring their behavior.

Such thought experiments were extremely disturbing to me because they undermined my job description. As the head of product development, I thought my job was to ensure the timely delivery of high-quality products and features. But if many of those features were a waste of time, what should I be doing instead? How could we avoid this waste?

I've come to believe that learning is the essential unit of progress for startups. The effort that is not absolutely necessary for learning what customers want can be eliminated. I call this validated learning because it is always demonstrated by positive improvements in the startup's core metrics. As we've seen, it's easy to kid yourself about what you think customers want. It's also easy to learn things that are completely irrelevant. Thus, validated learning is backed up by empirical data collected from real customers.

WHERE DO YOU FIND VALIDATION?

As I can attest, anybody who fails in a startup can claim that he or she has learned a lot from the experience. They can tell a compelling story. In fact, in the story of IMVU so far, you might have noticed something missing. Despite my claims that we learned a lot in those early months, lessons that led to our eventual success, I haven't offered any evidence to back that up. In hindsight, it's easy to make such claims and sound credible (and you'll see some evidence later in the book), but imagine us in IMVU's early months